

Chapter 67-1

—Why would you go provoke a lunatic who would personally kill her own daughter?

This statement shocked Liang Shi far more than the latter one.

Liang Shi looked at Qiu Zimin in astonishment, opening her mouth with difficulty: "You're saying her daughter was killed by her own hand?"

"If you know, then stop provoking her." Qiu Zimin sneered coldly, "Liang Shi, you should know that leaving you alive is already my mercy."

"But why would Yang Jiani kill her own daughter? Where did the current daughter come from? Why hasn't anyone questioned this? Can there really be two identical people in this world?" Liang Shi struck while the iron was hot.

Qiu Zimin looked at her, her voice suddenly softening, carrying a hint of laziness and mockery, "Liang Shi, stop trying to dig for information from me. Some things—the more you know, the faster you die."

The last few words were spoken almost syllable by syllable, sounding like a threat.

"We're a society ruled by law." Liang Shi sneered coldly, "Does your upper-class society not follow the law?"

"We do, we're the most law-abiding group of people." Qiu Zimin glanced at her lightly: "But there are too many accidents in this world. You can't possibly avoid encountering an accident for your entire life."

Liang Shi: "....."

She exhaled lightly, "So the current Qi Jiao was adopted?"

"What does it have to do with you?" Qiu Zimin snorted coldly: "Instead of having the effort to worry about others, you'd better worry more about what you'll do in the future."

Liang Shi looked at her, knowing she couldn't get any information about Yang Jiani and Qi Jiao from her, so she changed direction: "So did you see Daoist Master Yunyin¹ that day?"

"I didn't." Qiu Zimin said: "I'm tired."

She glanced at Liang Shi's pocket, "You don't really think having a recording can prove anything, do you?"

Liang Shi's hand tightened slightly, but she suppressed her surprise, not lowering her head to look at her pocket. Instead, she pretended to be calm and smiled: "What do you mean?"

"Your phone." Qiu Zimin showed a mocking expression: "I stopped playing these tricks twenty years ago."

After suppressing the initial fear and trepidation, Liang Shi finally came to her senses.

She had unconsciously been following Qiu Zimin's emotional rhythm.

Liang Shi steadied her mind and said coldly: "Although the recording can't prove anything, it can guide public opinion."

Although Liang Shi had never thought of doing this, recording in advance was only for self-protection.

"As you wish." Qiu Zimin curved her lips in a cold smile, "Pushing your adoptive mother into the center of public opinion—Liang Shi, you really are something."

"We haven't reached that point yet." Liang Shi brushed off the specks of dust on her clothes, "It's a bit early to say such things."

"I need to rest." Qiu Zimin returned to that elegant posture, glancing at Liang Shi arrogantly: "Close the door on your way out."

Liang Shi walked toward the exit, but paused when she reached the door, "Have you ever thought about what your children would do if they knew your true face?"

"My true face?" Qiu Zimin laughed lowly, her voice faint, carrying a hint of coldness: "What is my true face? Vicious? A venomous woman?"

"You know yourself." Liang Shi said: "Those things you've done....."

"What have I done?" Qiu Zimin retorted: "Can't a mother be foolishly superstitious? Can't she be deceived by others?"

"Liang Shi." Qiu Zimin said: "No matter what, I raised you all these years, and now you turn around and bite the hand that fed you, and you even want to stand on the moral high ground to call me vicious. You should look in the mirror and see whose heart is truly black!"

Liang Shi's breathing tightened.

For a moment, she almost doubted whether her approach was correct.

It seemed that after Qiu Zimin put it that way, she really was quite despicable.

How could she say those things and do those things to the adoptive mother who worked so hard to raise her?

Even resistance shouldn't be allowed.

But it was only for a moment.

A moment later, Liang Shi turned her back to her and smiled helplessly with a bitter smile, sighing softly: "Your rhetoric is indeed impressive."

But she was no longer the original Liang Shi.

However, after this encounter, Liang Shi came to appreciate even more how terrifying Qiu Zimin was.

This person wasn't simply bad or stupid; on the contrary, she was very clever.

She could give you information, but would never let her vulnerabilities fall into your hands.

She would hysterically scold you, insult you, and oppress you from the moral high ground, but wouldn't give you the chance to insult her in return.

After all, she was the one who raised you. If you were a grateful child, you would never do these things.

It was precisely because of this that the original host had been so thoroughly dominated.

The original host went crazy and acted badly without restraint, but would never harm the Liang family's related interests.

And in front of Qiu Zimin, she was as docile as a lamb. Occasionally she would bare her fangs, but would become obedient again because of those words.

If a child grew up under this kind of rhetoric, no matter what they became, it would seem natural.

Qiu Zimin looked at her innocently, "What rhetoric do I have? Are you going to say I'm gaslighting² you again? Don't just learn a trending internet term and apply it to me. Who changed you? Who told you that once you discovered I'm not your biological mother, you could turn around and question everything I've done? No matter what, I raised you. The grace of raising is greater than the grace of giving birth."

Liang Shi exhaled heavily and said without any flattery or ulterior motive: "You're very impressive."

A calm Qiu Zimin was in an invincible state.

Even in a palace intrigue drama³, she would be a ruthless character who could survive fifty episodes.

But she had a weakness.

Liang Shi said gently: "I hope your daughter hasn't encountered parents like you, the way I did."

"Just because someone raised you doesn't mean they can be called parents and deserve gratitude." Liang Shi slowly turned her head, her eyes containing a bright light, "After all, no parent would want to cultivate their own child into a psychopath and send them to a psychiatric hospital."

"Shut up!" Mentioning her biological daughter, Qiu Zimin suddenly became emotional, "My Nannan⁴ would never be like you, unable to distinguish right from wrong! So ungrateful!"

Liang Shi smiled gently and calmly asked back: "Is that so?"

Qiu Zimin threw a cushion at her, "Get out! All these years you've stolen her position, occupied the love that should have been hers, and now you're here to maliciously speculate about her! Get out! This family has no room for you!"

Liang Shi bent down, extended her long arm to catch the cushion, her voice still gentle but firm and powerful, "Ms. Qiu, under the sunlight, darkness will ultimately have nowhere to hide."

When sunlight shines down, there may be shadows.

But as long as it's bright enough and righteous enough, the shadows will no longer exist.

Footnotes:

¹ Daoist Master Yunyin: A Daoist priest or master. Daoism (also spelled Taoism) is a traditional Chinese philosophy and religion. Religious practitioners often use titles like "Daoshi" (道士, Daoist priest) or "Daozhang" (道长, Daoist Master). "Yunyin" (云隐) means "Cloud Hidden."

² Gaslighting: The original Chinese uses "PUA" (Pick-Up Artist), which in Chinese internet culture has evolved to mean psychological manipulation and emotional abuse, similar to gaslighting. The term is used to describe manipulative behavior in relationships where one person undermines another's perception of reality.

³ Palace intrigue drama: Known as "gongdou ju" (宫斗剧) in Chinese, these are historical dramas centered on power struggles, scheming, and survival tactics among concubines and imperial family members in ancient Chinese palaces. They typically feature intelligent, calculating characters who use manipulation and strategy to survive.

⁴ Nannan: An affectionate nickname meaning "daughter" or "little girl." The character 囡 (nān) is a dialectal term (particularly in Wu dialect regions like Shanghai) used as an endearing way to refer to a daughter or young girl. The repetition (囡囡) makes it even more affectionate.

Chapter 67-2

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When Liang Shi left, she closed the door behind her, then took out her phone from her pocket. The recording showed thirty minutes.

She hadn't expected that just talking and pulling back and forth could take half an hour.

Her understanding of Qiu Zimin had risen to a new level.

It was only at this moment that she suddenly realized Qiu Zimin had been raised in a prominent family since childhood and had witnessed all kinds of tactics and schemes.

How could she not see through her little tricks?

But Liang Shi really hadn't thought about using the recording for anything.

Even if she exposed it in front of her two brothers, the ones who would ultimately be hurt would only be the two brothers.

Having lived for over thirty years, already established in their careers, only to discover that their mother was a hypocritical and evil person—this would be truly cruel.

Even if she wanted to let the two brothers know these things, there was no need to use the recording.

The photos saved on her phone could explain everything.

But none of these could become tools to punish Qiu Zimin.

As for how to punish her, Liang Shi hadn't figured it out yet.

However, there was one thing—Liang Shi wanted to live well, to live brilliantly.

Didn't Qiu Zimin want her to become a psychopath rejected by everyone?

She would do the opposite.

She wanted to become a shining star that many people loved.

After Liang Shi came downstairs, she found everyone's eyes focused on her. She just shrugged and smiled, "We just chatted casually. We'll be leaving first."

After speaking, she took Xu Qingzhu and left the old mansion.

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The autumn climate in this coastal city was changeable. The morning had been quite clear, with the sun even coming out to dry the traces of last night's rainstorm.

Yet on their way home, dark clouds gathered densely, and a drizzling rain began to fall.

After returning home, Liang Shi listened to the recording of her conversation with Qiu Zimin again. It seemed like a lot was said, but actually nothing substantial was revealed.

Only that matter about Qi Jiao.

Liang Shi was in her room pondering without a clue, deep in thought, when there was a knock on the door.

Xu Qingzhu stood at the doorway and asked: "I ordered bubble tea. Do you want some?"

As an actress, she had always respectfully declined high-calorie things like bubble tea.

Plus, Liang Shi didn't used to like eating sweets, so she probably didn't drink bubble tea more than ten times a year.

But now that Xu Qingzhu was inviting her, she got up and followed her to the living room.

Xu Qingzhu's double cream topping¹ looked full of happiness, while what was left for Liang Shi was a cup of brown sugar pearl milk tea².

No other toppings.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Considering you'll be joining the production team soon, you'd better not eat things like cream topping."

Liang Shi chuckled lightly, "Do you know there's a type of person who has a constitution that doesn't gain weight?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Aren't I one?"

Liang Shi: ".....?"

She was amused, "I am too, so why do you have double cream topping while I don't?"

"Do you really want it?" Xu Qingzhu glanced at the two cups of bubble tea, "Then should I order you another cup now?"

"No need, no need." Liang Shi had just been teasing her casually. Seeing her pick up her phone, she immediately said: "I'll just drink this one."

"Mainly because there's a two-cup minimum for delivery." Xu Qingzhu said: "If I order another cup for you, I'd have to drink another cup myself, and I can't drink that much."

Liang Shi: "....."

She reasonably suspected that her cup was just to make up the order for Xu Qingzhu.

"No need to suspect." Xu Qingzhu caught her doubtful gaze and admitted very directly: "It was for the minimum order discount."

Liang Shi: "....."

Even knowing it was to make up the minimum order discount, Liang Shi still thought this cup of bubble tea tasted quite good.

Footnotes:

¹ Double cream topping: Known as "shuangbei naigai" (双倍奶盖) in Chinese, this refers to a popular bubble tea topping made of a thick, creamy, salted cheese foam that sits on top of the tea. "Double" means an extra-thick layer of this topping.

² Brown sugar pearl milk tea: Known as "hēitáng zhēnzhū nǎichá" (黑糖珍珠奶茶) in Chinese, this is a popular bubble tea variety featuring chewy tapioca pearls coated in brown sugar syrup mixed with milk tea. It's considered a classic, simpler version compared to drinks with additional toppings.

Chapter 67-3

Outside, it was raining. The fine raindrops condensed on the glass, transforming into slender streams of water that slid down to the windowsill, then along the gray walls and into the earth.

Xu Qingzhu turned on the TV and asked Liang Shi what she wanted to watch.

Liang Shi said whatever.

Then Xu Qingzhu opened a movie—*City of Fantasy*.

Starring: Yang Shuyan.

Liang Shi: "?"

Just one minute into the opening credits, Xu Qingzhu suddenly said: "Oh right, I received a package today."

"What?" Liang Shi still had a pearl in her mouth that she hadn't swallowed, and asked indistinctly: "A gift?"

"Sort of."

Xu Qingzhu bent down slightly, pulled open the coffee table drawer in the living room, and then took out a photo album the size of A4 paper.

Exquisitely bound, it came in a box.

She paused the TV, then focused intently on unpacking the box. After opening it, the cover that was revealed showed a still from Yang Shuyan's film.

The very cool and beautiful red outfit look from that period costume movie.

Liang Shi: "?"

"When I was on that video call last time, I mentioned to Yang Shuyan that I really liked this film of hers, and then she sent me a set of exquisite merchandise, with every page autographed." Xu Qingzhu flipped through it: "She's really very thoughtful."

"Yes." Liang Shi bit down on her straw, "You're the investor daddy¹, so of course she's thoughtful with you."

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu turned her face to the side, "Why so sour?"

Liang Shi immediately widened her eyes and shook her head: "I'm not. But do you know that Sister Ying and Yang Shuyan....."

She paused, the emotions conveyed in her eyes very rich.

"Are a couple?" Xu Qingzhu asked: "But their fans are fighting quite ridiculously. They're practically arguing every day."

"You even watch their fans argue?" Liang Shi was astonished.

"Hm?" Xu Qingzhu said: "I even joined a Weibo² fan group."

Liang Shi: "....."

"The fans don't know about the celebrities' relationships. They're all just guessing blindly." Liang Shi tried hard to steer the direction elsewhere, "Last time when I went to audition for *Afterglow*, Yang Shuyan was there too."

"Mm, I heard she'll have a special appearance in it." Xu Qingzhu looked like she knew everything, then looked at Liang Shi: "Teacher Liang, I'd like to interview you—having just entered the industry and already performing alongside two of the industry's top powerhouse Best Actresses³, what does it feel like?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She was silent for a moment, then said with feigned profundity, "We haven't started filming yet. I'll tell you after we finish shooting."

Xu Qingzhu carefully put away that set of merchandise while saying with a smile: "Alright, then I'll be waiting for Teacher Liang's three-thousand-word reflective essay."

Liang Shi: "?"

What kind of important figure was she?

Why did she have to write three thousand words?!

Liang Shi glanced at her, "Is it because I'm working with your goddess that you want me to write a three-thousand-word reflection?"

"Ah?" Xu Qingzhu was taken aback, then smiled after a moment: "My goddess? Who?"

Liang Shi glanced at the box she had put in the drawer, "There, Yang Shuyan."

"I suppose you could say that." Xu Qingzhu turned on the TV, the corners of her mouth always holding a smile, "Teacher Liang, work hard. Maybe in the future you'll be promoted to become my new goddess."

Liang Shi: "?"

Why did this matter require effort?

Yang Shuyan's line delivery was excellent, her enunciation clear, and full of emotion. Just two lines could immerse people in the scene.

After being modest for over twenty years, Liang Shi suddenly said, "My acting isn't any worse than hers."

Xu Qingzhu didn't even look at her, her tone perfunctory: "Is that so? Then Teacher Liang is really amazing. I look forward to the day you become hugely popular."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Besides, people you see every day can't become goddesses." Liang Shi added another point.

"Ah? Why not?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "Goddesses need to exist ethereally and intangibly, and also, distance creates beauty."

Xu Qingzhu almost choked on a mouthful of bubble tea, then looked at Liang Shi and asked with particular seriousness and surprise: "So, is Teacher Liang jealous?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She immediately denied it: "How could that be?"

Xu Qingzhu chuckled lightly, "It's okay, I understand."

Liang Shi was bewildered: "Understand what?"

"Don't worry, Teacher Liang." Xu Qingzhu patted her shoulder, "Even if I like Yang Shuyan's acting, I won't stop supporting you. I can..... stan both⁴."

Liang Shi: "....."

A few seconds later, Liang Shi removed her hand, grinding her teeth as she said: "You might as well jump ship⁵."

Xu Qingzhu held back and held back, but couldn't hold back her laughter.

But after laughing, she comforted Liang Shi, "Teacher Liang, in the future you'll have lots of fans just like Yang Shuyan."

Liang Shi: ".....Oh."

After several rounds of speechlessness, Liang Shi watched the movie seriously.

Yang Shuyan indeed had a face made for movies, with an innate sense of sophistication.

Her acting was also outstanding. Several veteran actors almost couldn't keep up with her performance.

So young, yet so capable—she must be a naturally talented actress.

Just like Sister Ying.

Footnotes:

¹ Investor daddy: In Chinese entertainment industry slang, "投资人'爸爸'" (tóuzīrén 'bàba') refers to wealthy investors or financial backers of projects. They're called "daddy" because they provide the money that makes projects possible. The term has slightly sarcastic undertones and sometimes implies that favors or special treatment may be exchanged for investment.

² Weibo: China's equivalent of Twitter/X, a major social media platform where celebrities interact with fans and where fan culture thrives. The full name is "Sina Weibo" (新浪微博).

³ Best Actresses: The Chinese term "影后" (yǐnghòu) literally means "Film Queen" or "Movie Queen," a title given to actresses who have won Best Actress awards at major film festivals or ceremonies. In this context, it refers to acclaimed, award-winning actresses with proven acting prowess.

⁴ Stan both: The original Chinese uses "双担" (shuāng dān), which means to be a fan of two celebrities simultaneously. "担" (dān) is fan slang for being a dedicated fan or supporter of a celebrity, derived from "担当" (dāndāng, to take responsibility). "双担" literally means being a fan who supports both.

⁵ Jump ship: The Chinese uses "爬墙" (pá qiáng), which literally means "climb the wall." In fan culture, it refers to a fan abandoning their current favorite celebrity to become a fan of someone else—essentially "jumping ship" or switching allegiances to a different idol.

Chapter 67-4

Liang Shi saw a jumping-off-a-building scene in the drama and suddenly spoke up: "Although it's rude to interrupt you while watching TV, I still have something to say."

Xu Qingzhu pressed pause and raised an eyebrow: "What is it?"

"I remember you once said that Qi Jiao jumped off a building in her third year of middle school, right?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "You're still investigating that matter with Qi Jiao?"

"Yes." Liang Shi said: "I saw her yesterday and found she still had wounds on her body. Rainbow said she often has those kinds of wounds on her body, so....."

She paused and didn't continue.

But Xu Qingzhu already understood.

Qi Jiao was still being abused, and she couldn't escape.

Although this was the Qi family's domestic affair, Liang Shi had also suffered this kind of abuse when she was young, and in her limited memories, that older sister had been good to her.

Even though she was very afraid and felt very wronged, she would still plead for young Liang Shi, would protect Liang Shi when her mother was hitting her, would urge Liang Shi to apologize and admit her mistakes, all just so she could suffer less beatings.

After hesitating, Liang Shi still played the conversation she had with Qiu Zimin today for Xu Qingzhu to hear.

Outside, the rain was falling harder and harder, with occasional thunderclaps.

It was clearly only a little past five o'clock, but the dark, oppressive clouds covered the sky, making it as gloomy as night.

The streetlights also came on earlier than usual.

Xu Qingzhu listened to the recording at double speed, and like Liang Shi, when she heard that line "So why would you go provoke a lunatic who would personally kill her own daughter," her expression showed surprise.

After listening to the end, she drew in a sharp breath of cold air, but the first thing she said was a conclusion: "She's planning to kick you out of the Liang family."

"I know." Liang Shi said: "I'm looking for a suitable place to live. Once I find one, I'll move out. I'll try to leave on my own before she kicks me out."

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu said: "I'll also have Cherry help me keep an eye out. When the time comes, let's move together."

She didn't take the opportunity to suggest separating or getting divorced, but instead planned to find another place that could accommodate both of them.

Liang Shi didn't bring up this matter either.

Her mind was now completely full of that sentence from Qiu Zimin. "So Yang Jiani personally killed her own daughter? Then who is the current Qi Jiao? She seems to know she's a replacement."

Xu Qingzhu nodded.

Because last time when Liang Shi went to find her, she had almost blurted out that Qi Jiao was already dead.

At that time, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu had speculated that she might have died in that jumping incident in the third year of middle school.

After all, from that point on, Qi Jiao had practically disappeared from public view.

But coincidentally..... Qiu Zimin said Yang Jiani herself had killed Qi Jiao.

Xu Qingzhu was also puzzled about one thing: "Is the current Qi Jiao someone who had plastic surgery? Had surgery to look like the original person. Then where is the original Qi Jiao's grave? According to Sister Ying, there's no way Yang Jiani wouldn't have made a grave for her daughter."

"That's also possible." Liang Shi said: "After all, now everyone thinks Qi Jiao is still alive."

"Can you tell where Qi Jiao had plastic surgery?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi thought about it, and based on her impressions from those she'd seen in the entertainment industry, answered: "Her nose seems to have been slightly augmented, she's also had her inner eye corners opened¹, and her mouth seems to have been plumped²."

"Then it wasn't major surgery." After Xu Qingzhu said this, she fell silent, her whole person sinking into a contemplative state.

Liang Shi also followed her train of thought, and a few minutes later, the two of them suddenly made eye contact and said in unison: "The orphanage!"

After speaking, the two of them smiled at the same time.

But their expressions quickly became grave again.

"Since the surgery wasn't extensive, it means this person's original appearance already resembled Qi Jiao somewhat. Plus, Qi Jiao's death should have been quite early, so the plastic surgery was done during adolescence." Liang Shi said: "Including after differentiation³, a person's appearance will still change, so no one knows that the current Qi Jiao isn't the original one."

"Right." Xu Qingzhu nodded: "It's impossible to encounter someone like this from normal people, so there are two scenarios."

"One is that this person's family is very poor, so poor that they would sell their daughter. She was bought by Yang Jiani to be a stand-in for her daughter. The other possibility is that Yang Jiani saw the current Qi Jiao at an orphanage. Because her daughter had passed away, she adopted this girl and transformed her into her own daughter."

More than ten years ago, identity information was far less complete than it is now.

The procedures for adopting a child from an orphanage weren't complicated either. If you had money, you could take a child away at any time.

So the latter possibility was the greatest.

After a moment of silence, Liang Shi said: "But there are still two scenarios now. One is that Yang Jiani first killed her daughter, then sought out a replacement in guilt and self-reproach, and found Qi Jiao. The other is that she felt her own daughter wasn't obedient enough, measured by her perverted standards, and then after seeing the current one, deliberately killed Qi Jiao and switched them....."

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If it was the latter, then the nature of this matter would be completely different.

How cruel would someone's heart have to be to do such a thing?

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu both fell silent, and the bubble tea in their hands had lost all its flavor.

After a while, Xu Qingzhu said: "I'll call Cherry."

Cherry's uncle had been doing charity work, sponsoring many orphanages and nursing homes, and Cherry had had a habit of regularly volunteering at orphanages and nursing homes since high school, so she might know more about these matters.

"Then I'll ask Sister Ying." Liang Shi said.

The two of them split up to take action.

Footnotes:

¹ Inner eye corners opened: Known as "开眼角" (kāi yǎnjiǎo) in Chinese, this is a cosmetic surgery procedure that removes skin at the inner corners of the eyes to make the eyes appear larger and more elongated. It's a common plastic surgery procedure in East Asia. There's also an outer eye corner procedure, but the inner corner procedure is more common.

² Plumped: Refers to "丰唇" (fēng chún) or lip augmentation/lip filler procedures to make lips appear fuller and more voluminous. This is typically done with injectable fillers.

³ Differentiation: Refers to the ABO dynamics concept where individuals "present" or develop into their designated secondary gender (Alpha, Beta, or Omega) during puberty. This is when their physical characteristics and pheromone production related to their ABO status fully manifest.

Chapter 67-5

Half an hour later, Xu Qingzhu shared the information she had gathered with Liang Shi.

There were many orphanages in Haizhou City, but most of them had been established within the past ten-plus years.

The largest orphanage from over ten years ago was Angel Orphanage, which housed nearly half of Haizhou City's orphans and disabled children, but five years ago, this orphanage was rebuilt and became Loving Care Nursing Home.

This orphanage had produced many remarkable people.

The former director had excellent connections and would often select the most suitable children for wealthy families who wanted to adopt. Those children, with their outstanding abilities, went abroad to study and then returned to become company executives, with some even inheriting family businesses.

But five years ago, the director suddenly fell ill. During his serious illness, he directly converted the orphanage into a nursing home.

Later, the director's mental state became abnormal. He said he had harmed the children and was a sinner, and so on. Then his son took over the nursing home's related affairs, and this director also lived in the nursing home.

Cherry used to often volunteer at Angel Orphanage when she was in high school, so she was very familiar with that director and the director's son.

Even now, she would occasionally visit the nursing home, though after starting work, she became busier and the frequency of visits greatly decreased.

In comparison, other orphanages seemed much more mediocre.

They didn't have as many outstanding people as Angel Orphanage. Most children there had difficulty getting adopted.

Cherry also thought Xu Qingzhu wanted to adopt a child, so she recommended a slightly better one to her: Spring Sprout Orphanage.

Supposedly the management there was also good, and all the children had access to education.

Xu Qingzhu smiled and brushed off this topic, then searched for all the orphanages in Haizhou City and made a list.

Although on the surface Angel Orphanage seemed most likely, they couldn't overlook the others either.

Of course, if Yang Jiani had the ability to adopt a child from somewhere else, then they would consider this a wasted effort.

But Xu Qingzhu felt that the current Qi Jiao had probably gotten plastic surgery abroad.

Over ten years ago, domestic plastic surgery technology wasn't well-developed, so it was difficult to achieve ideal results.

Meanwhile, the information Liang Shi obtained from asking Zhao Ying was about the same as before.

But Zhao Ying went to carefully and thoroughly ask her dear mother again, and then obtained an important clue: Yang Jiani used to sponsor three orphanages—Angel Orphanage, Spring Sprout Orphanage, and New Voice Orphanage.

And supposedly in the year Qi Jiao jumped off the building, Mrs. Qi stayed secluded and rarely interacted with people.

After the two of them integrated the information, they basically locked onto Angel Orphanage as the target.

They might also need to check other places, but only after visiting Angel Orphanage and not obtaining any leads there.

After a long while, Liang Shi exhaled lightly, "Why does everyone think that just because you raised someone, you can be called a parent?"

This was quite a heavy topic.

Liang Shi didn't like discussing family affection matters with people. For one, she couldn't remember her parents and had no memories related to them.

Although her grandparents had been especially good to her, occasionally she would still think of her parents.

"I don't know." Xu Qingzhu said in a heavy voice: "Probably because becoming a parent doesn't require taking an exam."

Having already investigated to this extent, Liang Shi simply made plans with Xu Qingzhu to visit Angel Orphanage—which was now Loving Care Nursing Home—tomorrow afternoon.

Chapter 67-6

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The rain never stopped. Perhaps because she had thought too much about matters related to Qi Jiao during the day.

In her dream, she returned once again to her childhood.

In that dim little room, Qi Jiao, wearing a princess dress, sat side by side with her on the floor. There were scabbed-over red marks on her wrist, and then she turned over the back of her hand and opened her palm, revealing a round cookie.

She sniffled, "I'm sorry, I could only get this much. Eat it quickly."

Liang Shi looked at that cookie, reached out to take it, and asked Qi Jiao in a low voice: "Sister, why is your mother like this?"

Qi Jiao buried her head in her knees. She said: "Mom is also very pitiful."

"I saw Dad when he was drunk....." Halfway through Qi Jiao's words, she heard the sound of the door moving. She immediately snatched the cookie from Liang Shi's hand, then threw it on the ground, and the two of them huddled together.

Yang Jiani was still wearing a qipao¹, gracefully swaying, but the hem of her qipao had been torn off a section, her hair was disheveled, and there were bloodstains at the corner of her mouth.

Her gaze toward the two children was very cold. Suddenly she smiled, "Why were you born?"

She asked very seriously, then crouched down, "Being born is suffering. Why be born?"

Qi Jiao's body trembled, but she still raised her small hand, tremblingly touching Yang Jiani's injured face, asking with a crying voice: "Mom, does it hurt?"

"Hurt?" Yang Jiani sneered coldly: "You won't hurt if you're dead."

She licked the bloodstain on her lip, "So..... my precious Jiaojiao, do you want to die with me? I'll take you with me."

"Oh right, and you too." Yang Jiani looked at Liang Shi: "You're not likeable when you're alive anyway. Might as well come along with us."

"Mom." Qi Jiao leaned forward and hugged Yang Jiani, burying her head in her neck, crying as she said: "I don't want to die."

"But what can you do by living?" Yang Jiani scoffed, "Living is painful."

"Don't take little sister to die either." Qi Jiao said: "Jiaojiao will be very obedient, will listen. Little sister is also very obedient."

.....

In the dream, she kept falling, everything before her eyes was emptiness and darkness.

Then the scene changed. In a field covered with green grass, the moon hung high in the sky. It should have been a dreamy scene, but she, dressed in tattered clothes, was running wildly through the field with a little girl with disheveled hair.

As if they would never get tired.

And as if voices were coming from all directions, people constantly shouting: "Stop!"

The little girl following behind her fell to the ground, her knee scraped raw. She crouched down and said firmly: "Get on!"

They just kept running like that, running across the empty field, hiding beneath the field ridge.

Ice and snow melted, grass sprouted, and there was the sound of a stream flowing.

Liang Shi first covered the little girl's mouth, and only released her hand after the footsteps of those searching disappeared.

After a long while, the little girl asked: "Sister, can we escape?"

"Yes, we can." Liang Shi said.

"You should run by yourself." The little girl said in a low crying voice: "My leg is injured. I'll drag you down."

"No." Liang Shi said: "I must take you with me."

"Why?" The little girl asked: "I'm a burden now."

"Because a sister once told me that sisters are supposed to protect their little sisters." Liang Shi touched the little girl's head, "I'm the older sister."

"Do you have a sister?" the little girl asked.

Liang Shi said: "Not a real sister, but she was very good to me."

The little girl said: "I don't have any sisters."

"Silly." Liang Shi smiled, holding the thin-framed girl: "From now on I'm your sister. Don't be afraid, sister will always protect you."

After a while, the little girl suddenly said: "Look! Fireflies!"

Liang Shi immediately closed her eyes: "Quick, make a wish."

.....

Her body seemed to be suspended and drowning in the deep sea, with people constantly pulling her down.

Then she suddenly opened her eyes.

What she saw was a pure white ceiling, and overcast skies.

The rain had stopped, but it was still cloudy.

Liang Shi lay in bed gasping for breath, trying to calm the emotions the nightmare had brought her.

After the luck value reached 80, Liang Shi had obtained some memories from the system, or rather, from the original host.

But they were all fragmentary, without any important information.

And this was another time she had dreamed of things related to her childhood.

There were different scenes in the dream.

She and a little girl were fleeing for their lives across an empty field. They made wishes to fireflies. They were caught by a group of people.

Then the dream came to an abrupt end.

She didn't even know what it was about.

This was the first time memories related to this little girl had appeared in Liang Shi's mind.

It still felt like something she had personally experienced.

After going through those previous dream sequences, she could now basically determine which memories belonged to the original host and which belonged to her.

Very clearly, both of these segments belonged to her.

But she didn't know under what circumstances the second segment had occurred, nor did she know who the little girl was.

However, Liang Shi didn't dwell on it too much. She was more concerned about Qi Jiao.

The older sister who had protected her when she was little.

Thinking about it still made her feel sad.

Because they were returning to the Xu family today, Liang Shi adjusted her emotions in her room before going out.

But Xu Qingzhu still saw at a glance that she wasn't in good condition and asked if she had a nightmare.

Liang Shi nodded, "I dreamed of Qi Jiao."

Xu Qingzhu served her a bowl of congee². Liang Shi nodded and said thank you.

Xu Qingzhu smiled, "Then let's find the truth as soon as possible and clear her name."

After finishing the meal, those unpleasant emotions in Liang Shi's heart finally subsided somewhat.

Xu Qingzhu was preparing things for the memorial service. Liang Shi watched as she put those items into a backpack, and suddenly asked: "Xu Qingzhu, if one day you discovered that your parents weren't your biological parents, what would you do? Would you look for your biological parents?"

Xu Qingzhu froze.

She was so clever. A moment later, she suddenly asked back with a smile: "Are you talking about me or are you talking about yourself?"

Footnotes:

¹ Qipao: Also known as cheongsam, a traditional form-fitting Chinese dress for women with a high collar and side slits. It originated in the 1920s-1930s in Shanghai and became iconic Chinese formal wear. The qipao is often associated with elegance and sophistication.

² Congee: Known as "粥" (zhōu) in Chinese, this is a rice porridge that's a staple breakfast food in Chinese cuisine. It's made by boiling rice in a large amount of water until it breaks down into a thick, creamy consistency. It's considered easy to digest and comforting, often served when someone is sick or as a light meal.